

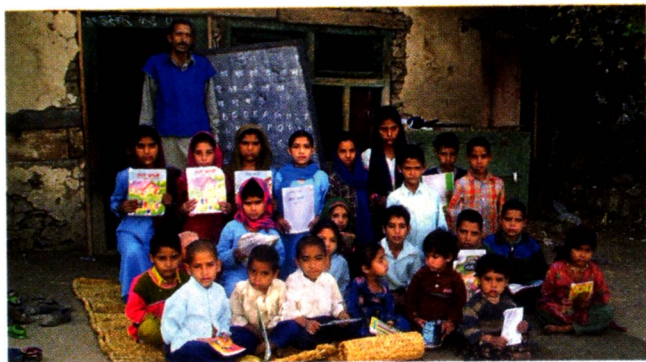
The Game Changers INSTITUTIONS

FRIENDS OF TRIBAL SOCIETY West Bengal

NO CHILD LEFT BEHIND

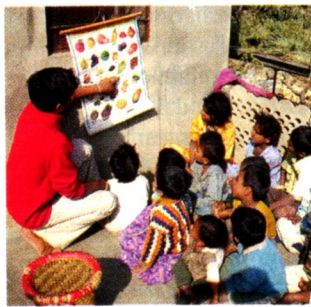
When Kolkata-based industrialist, the late Madan Lal Agarwal, 74, lent a helping hand to famine-struck villagers in Dhanbad, Jharkhand, in 1986, little did he know that the act of benevolence would change the lives of tribals across the country. Three years later, he set up the Friends of Tribal Society (FTS) along with a chartered accountant friend M.L. Jain and 12 others. "There are about nine crore tribals in India now and if such a huge number remains backward, can we progress? Once a child attends our school, they are fit to get into at least Class III of a regular school," says Jain. After studying in these schools, many children make it to the formal schools. Each FTS-run school has 20-30 students but only one teacher. Generally, a local person with reasonable qualifications is selected to teach at these schools. The school has full-time supervisors as well. FTS also has a "Van Yatra" programme that takes city-dwellers on a tour of tribal areas to create awareness about their welfare. Fortunately, funding isn't a problem. "We have never got any aid from the government. Donations from patrons helps us run the schools," says Jain. With a budget of Rs 15 crore for 2008-09 for its 28,000 one-teacher schools, the FTS now has about 24 chapters all over the country, giving the marginalised an opportunity to join the mainstream.

by Elora Sen



The FTS runs about **28,000** one-teacher schools across India.

THE FTS HAS 24 CHAPTERS ALL OVER THE COUNTRY, INCLUDING KOLKATA, MUMBAI, AGRA, DELHI, AMONG OTHERS



MANDAR DEOCHAR



PRINCIPAL SHALINI SACHDEVA WITH THE STUDENTS OF K.C. THACKERAY VIDYA NIKETAN

THERMAX SOCIAL INITIATIVE FOUNDATION Pune

CARE FULL

For the last three years, not a single student at the K.C. Thackeray Vidya Niketan School has dropped out. The reason: this Pune Municipal Corporation (PMC)-run vernacular school with 180 students was taken over by the Thermax Social Initiative Foundation. It's now an English-medium school. "The intelligent children were being pulled out because the parents wanted them to be educated in English," says Mahesh Ladkat, chairman, school board, PMC. The foundation also traverses through the Pune slums and brings children to Savitribai Phule School for free education, a different model from Vidya Niketan which holds an examination for admission. "We were already educating underprivileged children through special classes. We decided to get inside a school and do the same," says Anu Aga, one of the three directors of the foundation. The aim is not literal learning only, but to make every child educated, cultured and confident.

by Jhilmil Motihar

The foundation which is running **two municipal** schools plans to take over another 10.